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Suppressing the expression of prejudice and prejudice reduction from childhood to adolescence: the view of genetic social psychology

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Abstract
We propose genetic social psychology as a theoretical framework to render intelligible both the suppression of the expression of prejudice and prejudice reduction in childhood. In particular, we explore the role of positive in-group norms in prejudice reduction in childhood and adolescence and their interplay with realistic and symbolic threats and subgroup identification in the post-conflict setting of Cyprus in a sample of 303 (51.5% female) 7–12-year-old students (mean age = 8.73 SD = 1.58) and 387 (60.2% female) 12–17-year-old students (mean age = 14.24 SD = 1.45) collected from a random sample of thirty-nine schools in the Greek Cypriot community. The following hypotheses were tested (a) threats and social identification will form a closer link with prejudice in older than younger children (H1), (b) positive in-group norms will "trump" threats in relation to the expression of prejudice in older children (H2), (c) strength of identification would enhance the effect of positive in-group norms in the expression of non-prejudicial views (H3), and finally (d) strength of identification would enhance the impact of positive norms on prejudice reduction in childhood, through a deeper conversion process of threat reduction, whereas on the contrary, it will diminish their impact in adolescence through ideological resistance (H4). We found broad support for our hypotheses and discuss practical implications of the findings for education.

Keywords *Cyprus* conflict · Prejudice · Childhood · Adolescence · Genetic social psychology · In-group norms

Understanding the views of children and adolescents in the context of ethnic conflicts is of crucial importance for conflict transformation. From a psychological perspective, the goal is to facilitate an optimal internal conflict resolution process that satisfies the needs of both conflicting sides leading to reconciliation at the grassroots level. Processes of conflict transformation were likened by the social psychologist and conflict resolution expert Herbert Kelman (2004) to social influence processes of compliance, identification, and

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internalization with the optimal process of internalization having the characteristics of a true ideological conversion (cf. Moscovici, 1980) towards the direction of more stable and generalized reconciliation attitudes (e.g., trust, reduced threats, empathy, inclusion of the other in the self, reconstruction of one sided narratives of victimization).

Education could be a positive or negative force for change in post-conflict settings. The formation of prejudice in the early years of schooling in childhood and later in adolescence and the question of whether the school context works towards overcoming violent conflict or whether it actually reinforces the dynamics that lead to the solidification of conflict and antagonism are thus of crucial importance.

Whilst formal developmental theories attempting to explain the development of prejudice in childhood have been proposed (see Aboud, 1988, 2008; Nesdale, 2001), for their formation, they have largely depended on race relations in the USA and UK and they have rarely been tested in such conflict transformation contexts; they have also been criticized for their lack of socio-cultural sensitivity (Barrett & Oppenheimer, 2011). In this paper, we test some hypotheses stemming from our wider effort to build a socio-cultural theoretical framework of genetic social psychology.

Genetic social psychology (GSP) is a dual process social developmental theory which explains how the representations of individuals change or not depending on the quality of social relations they are part of, either through internalized change or merely superficial compliance in social influence processes of social interaction. Epistemologically, it is a social constructivist framework building on the traditions of other genetic philosophies and theories from Goethe, James Marc Baldwin, Jean Piaget, Serge Moscovici, Anne-Nelly Perret Clermont, Gabriel Mugny, Willem Doise, and Gerard Duveen who were all interested in the study of how cognitive structures, knowledge, or representations change from one form to another form through processes of dialogue, social interaction, and social influence.

As a social developmental theory, it is interested in three processes of change in different timescales: (a) microgenetic processes describe change in representations through social interaction in the context of a dialogue or communicate instance (for example, a change in thoughts and feelings towards a member of an enemy group through intergroup contact), (b) ontogenetic processes that describe change in the representations of a single individual about an object of knowing through the life span and (for example, the change in feelings of prejudice of a single individual from childhood to adolescence), and (c) sociogenetic processes that describe change in the representations of a single group in historical time about an object (for example, representations of a group about an enemy "other" through the decades influenced by mass mediated processes). As argued by Lloyd & Duveen (1990), microgenetic processes are the motor for the other two genetic processes (ontogenesis and sociogenesis). One of the main goals of genetic social psychology is to render intelligible the articulation of the three genetic processes.

This study aims at a deeper exploration of the complexity of the reconstructive potential of social influence processes and group dynamics in prejudice reduction in two different age groups in the transition from childhood to adolescence in a post-conflict setting. In its application to the field of prejudice reduction, GSP critically engages developmental theories that attempt explanations of the development of prejudice in childhood like Aboud (1988) and Nesdale (2001) and more general social psychological theories relating to social influence processes like norm internalization (Crandall et al., 2002) and ideological conversion (Moscovici, 1980), as well as work around contact hypothesis (Allport, 1954). We propose that there are two routes to prejudice reduction: (a) superficial compliance to in-group norms or superficial intergroup

contact just affecting the expression or not of prejudiced emotions, which can even reinforce negative stereotypes, without reworking of the feelings of threats, empathy, inclusion of the other in the self, trust, and critical approach to one-sided victimization narratives and (b) a deep route which entails either qualitative intergroup contact or internalization of in-group norms through cognitive restructuring of values, ideas, and practices related to reconciliation attitudes (threats, empathy, inclusion of the other in the self, trust, critical approach to one-sided victimization narratives). This deeper route is facilitated by the four conditions originally proposed by Allport (1954) which is equal status, common goal, intergroup co-operation, and support by authorities.

The Cyprus context

Cyprus is since 1974 a divided island in the Eastern Mediterranean between the Greek Cypriot and the Turkish Cypriot community. In 1960, Cyprus gained its independence, and a consociational partnership between Greek Cypriots and Turkish Cypriots was established with the establishment of the Republic of Cyprus, a unitary state that joined the UN. The divergent national aspirations of the two communities and conflict over power sharing at the elite level led to "the troubles" of 1963–1964 in the form of violent inter-communal clashes. A coup in 1974, aimed at the union of Cyprus with Greece, engineered by the Greek military junta, and executed by extremist Greek Cypriot nationalists and a Greek military contingent in Cyprus, prompted a military invasion by Turkey that led to fatalities, mass executions, ethnic cleansing and major displacements of the population, and the division of the island into two ethnically homogeneous areas. This eventually resulted in the establishment of a breakaway state by the Turkish Cypriot leadership in the north, which is recognized only by Turkey (see Papadakis, 2005).

Almost twenty years later, in April 2003, checkpoints through the green line, the geographic line of division between the two communities, were partially opened by the Turkish Cypriot administration and Turkey, permitting thus people from Greek and Turkish Cypriot community to visit the north and the south part of the island respectively. After a failed attempt to resolve the problem with a referendum in 2004, there have been intermittently negotiations to solve the problem in the form of bi-zonal and bi-communal federation (Papadakis, 2005, 2008). Towards this aim after 2008, a number of bi-communal technical committees have been established to promote confidence building measures in various spheres. One of the last committees established was the bi-communal technical committee of education announced by the leaders of the two communities in 2015 tasked to find ways to overcome the high levels of prejudice and distrust registered in previous research amongst students (Makriyianni, 2006). The work of this technical committee has been instrumental in suggesting and implementing theoretically sound confidence building measures between the two communities in the educational system. One of the major achievements of the committee was the implementation of an educational contact scheme in 2016 called "Imagine" that brought students and teachers from the two communities for the first time during school hours to meet each other, play, and interact around principles of peace education at the Home for Co-operation in the UN patrolled Buffer Zone in Nicosia.

Prejudice reduction in post-conflict settings and the role of in-group norms

From the perspective of prejudice reduction, structured opportunities for intergroup contact are of crucial importance as they directly aim to not only reduce intergroup anxiety of the no-contact default for most of the students but beyond that also promote engaging, equal status quality contact (Allport, 1954; Pettigrew & Tropp, 2006) that will facilitate realistic threat reduction (Stephan & Stephan, 2000) through the promotion of the philosophy of co-operation (Piaget, 1932) and positive interdependence (Sherif, 1936), reduce symbolic threat through the realization of various similarities between the two communities of Cyprus, cultivate empathy and the inclusion of self, and build trust leading to an overall reduction of the ethos of conflict (Techiman & Bar-Tal, 2008) which is dominant in post-conflict settings.

The dominance of the ethos of conflict in Cyprus comes not only from negative media discourse but closer to our present focus from an overabundance of practices of commemoration, and history teaching in the case of Greek Cypriots relating to the collective trauma of 1974, most of them happening in public schools many times a year from nursery onwards. For example, in the Greek Cypriot educational system soon after the invasion of Turkey in Cyprus in 1974, an educational policy was implemented named as *Den Xechno* (I do not forget) that from the early years of childhood creates in children a feeling of one-sided victimization by Turkey. This is a policy that has been criticized by academics in Cyprus who saw a number of problems in its rationale (Christou, 2006). According to Christou (2006), this policy promoted an "empty imagination" for students since it was only focused on properties lost in the northern occupied part of Cyprus but offered no positive vision for the reestablishment of relationships of co-operation with the Turkish Cypriot community of Cyprus, with which power sharing would have to be reestablished under a federal arrangement. This second source of knowledge about a victimized collective identity by out-group members (mostly referring to past victimization by Turkey) leads early on to the internalization of a core narrative of a sense of collective victimhood directly related to projected threats relating to the future of intercommunal relations in Cyprus and distrust (Psaltis et al., 2017b). Widespread threats and fears about enemy out-groups are one of the most prominent features of both ongoing conflicts (Teichman & Bar-Tal, 2008) and post-conflict societies undergoing a process of conflict transformation before a formal solution to the problem.

This overabundance of negative messages is often amplified by significant in-group others (parents, teachers, friends, peers), which leads to formation of what is known in the social psychological literature as in-group norms. In-group norms are a set of assumptions held by members of a group concerning the appropriate attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors to be displayed by group members. Norms mark group boundaries and describe and prescribe how group members should behave, and importantly for our present focus, become a source of normative social influence. The dominant norms (e.g., assuming it is acceptable in our group to make negative comments about an out-group, or that it is ok not to come into contact with members of the out-group) further exacerbate threats and fears internalized in earlier socialization.

Still, Cyprus has been undergoing a process of conflict transformation in the recent years, end especially after the opening of the checkpoints in 2003 in the UN patrolled Buffer Zone in Cyprus party reflected also in educational policy (see Zembylas et al., 2016). In 2015 and 2016, the ministry of education, amongst a positive honeymoon period

of positive statements and joint public appearances of the two leaders of the communities, made linkages between anti-racist education and peace education in circulars sent to schools in the beginning of the school years 2015–2016 and 2016–2017 setting the goals of the year and also supported the implementation of the "Imagine" program initiated by the bi-communal technical committee of education and implemented by the bi-communal NGO Association for Historical Dialogue and Research. In such a context of a transition in policies, one might expect that the inertia of the *Den Xechno* policy could cause resistance (Duveen, 2001) by both students, parents, and teachers for the implementation of the policy and lead to tensions and debates in the public sphere more generally. Nevertheless, to the extent that new positive in-group norms are formed through the various confidence building measures, this could also lead to both reductions in the public expression of prejudice as well as prejudice reduction through internalization of In-group norms.

It is our aim in this paper to explore whether (a) students recognize the novel positive in-group norms that promote intercommunal contact and positive bi-communal relations and (b) test the two possible ways (compliance or internalization) that such positive norms could lead to prejudice reduction in both the students of elementary school (7–12 year olds) and secondary school (12–17 years old) in a sample of the student population of Greek Cypriot children of the public schools. Beyond these two basic questions, there are a number of more specific hypotheses that could be derived from the theoretical framework we are proposing and previous empirical findings from the field of social developmental psychology.

Prejudice development theories

Most prejudice development theories and research have concentrated on the childhood years (4–12 years of age) with a particular focus on the role of social-cognitive developmental (Aboud, 1988) and motivational processes (Nesdale, 2001) in prejudice formation. According to Aboud (1988, 2008) who has been influenced by Piaget's work on children's cognitive development, feelings of prejudice and biased attitudes in children peak at the age of 5–7 and then decline as they further develop their cognitive abilities. She claims that the emergence of cognitive abilities during the concrete operational stage, such as for instance, the cognitive ability of conservation, or multiple classification skills, contributes to the greater attribution of importance to individual traits and characteristics rather than collective ones when assessing other individuals allowing children over the age of 7 to start recognizing that both in-group and out-group members can have both positive and negative traits. This more flexible way of thinking is less stereotypical, thus leading to a gradual reduction of prejudice in late childhood.

On the contrary, the motivational social identity development theory (SIDT) (Nesdale, 2004) predicts that children before 6–7 years of age usually exhibit only in-group favoritism without out-group derogation. Prejudice can emerge after this age depending on the extent to which (a) children identify with their social group or (b) prejudice is a norm held by the members of the child's social group or (c) the in-group members believe that their group is threatened in some way by members of the outg-roup" (Nesdale, 2001). Although in the original formulation of SIDT the three factors were presented as having independent effects on prejudice formation, later research (Nesdale et al. 2005) suggested that interactive effects between threats and norms are also possible.

A meta-analysis by Raabe and Beelmann (2011) shed more light on the issue of the developmental trajectory of prejudice. These authors found that there was a significant

mean level increase in prejudiced attitudes from early to middle childhood and then reduction of prejudice in late childhood thus supporting Aboud's (1998, 2003) proposition but only for prejudice levels of high status or majority groups towards minority groups. When exploring attitudes towards national out-groups or the attitudes of low status groups towards high status groups, this was not the developmental trajectory of prejudice. There was also more heterogeneity in prejudiced attitudes from one socio-cultural context to another with higher prejudice levels in post-conflict settings. This variation is especially prominent in adolescence (Barrett & Oppenheimer, 2011; Miklikowska, 2017). In this age group in post-conflict settings, social identity gets entangled in the context of ethnic antagonisms forming part of a more general ethos of conflict (Teichman & Bar-Tal, 2008) and there is more contestation between hawkish and dovish ideologies even in schools.

Interestingly enough, the seminal work of Piaget and Weil (1951) and the theoretical framework of GSP that draws on Piaget's social psychology (Piaget, 1932, 1995) that we are developing would predict the meta-analysis findings above. In Piaget's work, prejudice about an out-group is only the tip of the iceberg of more general representations about both in-group and out-group that also relates to the sense of belonging of the child and part whole relations with the homeland as well as the content of the representations that surround children about in-group and out-groups.

Thus, our reading of Piaget and Weil (1951) is more properly social psychological than the one offered by Frances Aboud's appropriation of Piaget as a mere stage theorist. It explains why one should not expect a universal prejudice reduction path as suggested by Aboud (1988). Prejudice can be sustained by various and diverse forms of thinking and some cognitive developmental skills allow an understanding of part whole relationships that will not be necessarily inclusive of all out-groups but in a selective manner depending on the context. Second, it suggests that both cognitive structuring and the content of the representations of the group (positive or negative) can influence prejudice in childhood and Piaget and Weil (1951) essentially support the idea that both prejudiced and non-prejudiced views could be sustained by negative or positive in-group norms correspondingly in late childhood and early adolescence.

However, with every developing stage, their application would concern a wider group (or one could talk of an expanding ethical horizon). In early childhood, the egocentric child is constrained in the here and now and has problems differentiating the subject from the object of knowledge. In middle childhood (6–12 years old), children could either show submission to family views (family sociocentrism-interpersonal focus) and values or decentration from these views. In early adolescence after 12 years old, there is the same dual possibility of submission or emancipation, through reciprocity and decentration, but this time from wider societal views and values (ethnocentrism-intergroup focus).

Thus, there are two ways that a reduced expression of prejudice could be sustained. The hallmark of deep, and not superficial, tolerant views for Piaget and Weil (1951) would be the mastery of part whole relations and the development of "that instrument of thought" reciprocity in thinking and not mere conformity to wider societal views. In terms of our discussion about the conflict transformation process, the hallmark of such a stance that challenges the dominant ethos of conflict would be reduced levels of threat, trust, inclusion of the other in self, empathy, perspective taking, and decentering from the one-sided victimization narratives of conflict.

This distinction between different ways of holding non-prejudicial views (as a thin layer of beliefs through conformity vs a real reconstruction of knowledge structures) is a unique feature of Piagetian social psychology (Kitchener, 2004; Psaltis & Zapiti, 2014) and a crucial element of GSP. Given the increasing agency of children with age (Martin & Gillespie,

2010), the diminishing role of relations of constraint, and the increasing role of relations of co-operation in childhood, we thus hypothesize that with increasing age normative influence would also take a deeper form influencing not only the mere expression of prejudice but actually leading to its reduction through well-known mechanisms like threat reduction, intergroup anxiety reduction, trust building, empathy, and perspective taking (Stephan & Stephan, 2000) also found in the effects of good quality contact on prejudice reduction. In fact, the increasing pre-occupation of adolescents with intergroup relations and their pursuing of political ideals and either hawkish or dovish ideologies suggests that with increasing age the sense of threats will form a closer link with prejudice. Similarly, a closer link between social identification with prejudice is expected given the increasing weaponization of identity in the discourse of an ethos of conflict compared to the younger ages, and in this paper, we aim to test this as our first hypothesis (H1).

Social norms and different ways of prejudice reduction

The role of in-group norms has been flagged as crucial from the early years of the study of prejudice through the work of Sherif (1936) and has been more recently revived by Crandall and his colleagues (Crandall et al., 2002). According to Sunstein (1996), social norms help individuals to be aware of the social acts being socially acceptable and of those that they are not. Perceived norms concern the way individuals represent collective norms at an individual level (Lapinski & Rimal, 2005). Therefore, social norms could substantially modify the way members of a particular social group would express out-group prejudice. Jetten et al. (1998) affirmed that social norms can reinforce or weaken in-group bias.

Research with adolescents and adults has revealed that group norms exert a significant influence on group members (see Brown, 2000, for a review). From a developmental perspective, Rutland (2004) claims that in late childhood and adolescence, in-group norms play a more significant role in prejudice reduction in comparison to cognitive developmental factors and he suggests that self-regulation of the expression of prejudiced attitudes can more clearly be seen in the divergent developmental paths of prejudice reduction when comparing prejudice towards ethnic groups in the same national context (less acceptable by public policy) with prejudice towards other countries (usually more acceptable). This is a point germane to post-conflict settings since "enemy" countries and their citizens could easily become the targets of animosity by the content of history teaching (Psaltis et al., 2017b) teachers, parents, and peers, whereas this might not be the case for other native ethnic, minority groups, or immigrants. As we have seen earlier, in the context of the Cyprus conflict, Turkey and the Turks comprise the enemy "other" for Greek Cypriots, whereas their attitude towards Turkish Cypriots is rather more ambiguous given the ongoing efforts to reach a compromise solution of power sharing with Turkish Cypriots that will end the occupation of Cyprus by the Turkish army.

Nevertheless, it is not uncommon to find younger children also expressing negative feelings towards TCs. Following Aboud's theoretical model, younger children prejudice towards Turkish Cypriots could be related to a binary and simplistic undifferentiated way of thinking, a negative reaction to anything related to Turkey (holding the position of the enemy) or difficulty in conceptually handling dual identities due to their mastery of part whole relationships (Makriyianni, 2006). In older children and adolescents, according to Teichman and Bar-Tal (2008), prejudice would be related to the internalization of an ethno-nationalist discourse, an ethos of conflict that homogenizes the out-group where TCs are not seen as different from Turks or are seen as responsible for beginning of the separation

of Cyprus with their "rebellion" in the period 1963–1964 and their withdrawal from the government. This creates an interesting tension between the feelings of threat that would be created and the positive message that students would get about TCs from the new pro-reconciliation policy. Thus, an interesting and important question is whether positive in-group norms could be effective in suppressing the expression of prejudice even in students who experience high threat and have not yet undergone a process of ideological conversion towards reconciliatory attitudes.

Empirically, the possible interplay of positive in-group norms with threats has rarely been studied in childhood. Realistic threats (threats to the well-being of the in-group) and symbolic threats (threat to values, norms, worldview, and identity of the in-group) are well-known proximal predictors of prejudice (Stephan & Stephan, 2000) and they are a central characteristic of what Teichman and Bar-Tal (2008) described as the ethos of conflict or the shared psychological repertoire (SPIR) that provides meaning, definitions, rules of practice, and codes for intergroup relationships that are usually sustained by one-sided narratives of victimization taught in schools (Psaltis et al., 2017b).

SIDT predicts that higher levels of threats will be related to higher levels of prejudice. Again, however, some findings suggest that group norms and out-group threat interactively affect the children's attitudes and behavior intentions (Nesdale et al., 2005). For example, how would the children react when their in-group had a norm of inclusion and the in-group was under threat from an out-group? Although SIDT is silent on the issue, it is plausible as suggested by Nesdale et al. (2005) that the children's concern for their group and its status in these circumstances would override the reference group's general injunctions concerning inclusiveness. Indeed, these researchers found, contrary to SIDT, that when both in-group norms and threats are present in a situation, they exert an interactive effect on children's prejudice that differs according to the age of the children. In particular, in comparing 7- to 9-year-old Anglo-Australian children, it was found that when the in-group had a norm of inclusion, the 7-year-old participants revealed liking for the out-group when the latter group did not threaten the in-group but the children expressed dislike when the out-group threatened the in-group, regardless of the in-group's norm of inclusion exhibiting a "threat trumps norms" finding in the younger children. On the contrary, the older 9-year-old children out-group attitudes did not differ from the neutral midpoint of the scale when the in-group had a norm of inclusion, regardless of whether the out-group did or did not threaten the in-group thus suggesting a "norm trumps threat" pattern in older children. In our view, such a process is indicative of the superficial compliance process of prejudice reduction which only concerns the public non-expression of existing prejudiced views, given that it takes place in children that entertain high levels of threat. From this finding, we derive H2 which predicts that the "norms trump threats" pattern would be found stronger in secondary than elementary school children.

In-group norms and subgroup identification

Findings from the normative approach to prejudice suggest that the degree of subgroup identification could be acting as a moderator of the relationship between in-group norms and the superficial expression of prejudice (Jetten et al., 1998) since high identifiers are more likely to conform to in-group norms compared to low identifiers. This prediction of these authors will be tested in the present work as H3.

Our GSP framework however, following Duveen (2001), suggests that the deeper reconstruction of knowledge, hence the internalization of norms and prejudice reduction as

described earlier, is a more complex social relational process that entails the renegotiation of identity as a dialogue between the processes of identification and being identified by others as an internal dialogue and co-ordination with the perspectives of out-groups. We therefore expect that the level of identification will moderate the process of norm internalization through the reduction of threats. Threats capture the zero-sum intentions of the out-group towards the in-group and the degree of perceived similarity or difference between the two groups more closely related to the processes of being identified (recognition) by out-groups.

The developmental perspective of Piaget and Weil (1951) also adds an additional layer of complexity to this process which has to do with which is the level of inclusivity of the in-group that acts as the relevant reference group the student identifies with in different ages. Piaget and Weil (1951) for once claim that in the transition from early to late childhood, a broadening of horizon from family to the nation state takes place in the child's thinking. As also suggested by SIDT (Nesdale et al., 2005), younger children are more likely to orient towards the in-group (thus engage in in-group love without necessarily engaging in out-group hate). However, older children are more likely to orient towards out-groups and thus attain a conceptual understanding of prejudice. Both this broadening of horizon and the emphasis on the importance of national identity in adolescence as part of the ethos of conflict in post-conflict settings (Teichman & Bar-Tal, 2008) suggest that issues of national identity become more important in adolescence.

In this sense whilst higher in-group identification in childhood would be related to closer adherence to the in-group norms of significant others (peers, friends, parents, teachers), in late childhood and adolescence, children are expected to obtain a wider concept of subgroup identification where their ethical horizon covers their in-group members in what Benedict Anderson (1991) aptly called an "imagined political community" of people who will never meet or know each other face to face. Higher identification with subgroup identity in adolescence could thus be more indicative of adherence to the ideals of the nation that could potentially undermine the internalization of positive in-group norms by significant in-group others leading to ideological resistance which is characteristic of post-conflict societies where students get ambiguous, if not outright contradictory, messages from various sources (Zembylas & Bekerman, 2012) about the need for reconciliation. Based on this rationale of GSP, we hypothesize (H4) that strength of identification would enhance the impact of positive norms on prejudice reduction in childhood, through threat reduction, whereas on the contrary, it will diminish their impact in adolescence. Support for our hypothesis would be revealed by the existence of an indirect path via symbolic threat which will play a bigger role in this prejudice reduction compared to the path via realistic threat as it more directly taps on definitions of identity, similarity, and difference between in-group and out-group compared to realistic threat that mostly taps on threatened well-being, economy, or power.

The current study

The principal aim of the current study is to investigate the potential role of positive in-group norms in facilitating the superficial expression of non-prejudiced views contra the deeper process of norm internalization that eventually leads to prejudice reduction via threat reduction by exploring the views of a student population of Greek Cypriots towards Turkish Cypriots in a sample that spans the age range from 7–17 years old. In this study, we aimed to not only establish the level of recognition of positive in-group norms about

social interactions and friendships with Turkish Cypriots in a period of positive developments in intercommunal relations in Cyprus (2015–2017) but also test the following hypotheses: (a) threats and social identification will form a closer link with prejudice in older than younger children (H1); (b) norms will "trump" threats in older children (H2); (c) strength of identification will increase the impact of in-group norms on the superficial expression of non-prejudicial views (H3); and finally (d), we expected that the deeper process of norm internalization that leads to the reduction of prejudice via the reduction of threats would be moderated by subgroup identification in opposite directions in the two age groups; this finding was expected to apply more on the indirect route of prejudice reduction via symbolic than realistic threat (H4).

To test H1, we will explore the bivariate correlations between the relevant variables in the two age groups, expecting to see a stronger link between norms, threats, identification, and prejudice in older than younger children. To test H2, we will explore the moderating role of threats on the impact of in-group norms on prejudice. To test H3, we will similarly explore the moderating role of subgroup identification on the impact of in-group norms on prejudice, and for testing H4, a moderated mediation model will be tested that will allow for both direct and indirect (through realistic and symbolic threat reduction) routes to prejudice reduction. Given previous findings that show gender effects on prejudice levels in youth (Kudrnáč, 2017) with girls being less prejudiced compared to boys and the assumption that urban environments would facilitate more tolerant attitudes given that they afford more intercultural interactions, we will control both of these variables when testing our hypotheses.

Methods

Sample

For this study, a sample of 303 students (51.5% female) 7–12 year olds (mean age = 8.73 SD = 1.58) from elementary education and 387 students (60.2% female) 12–17 year olds from secondary education (mean age = 14.24 SD = 1.45) collected from a random sample of school classes of thirty-nine schools from all districts of Cyprus after the Ministry of Education and Culture of Cyprus approved the research protocol and approval was given also by the Cyprus National Bioethics Committee. Parental informed consent was secured by giving to parents through school authorities printed informed consent forms. Also, before starting to administer the questionnaires, any students that they did not want to participate to the research had the right to withdraw from it. Response rate was 32%. About 33% of parents were unskilled, menial service, semiskilled workers and machine operators, skilled craftsmen, clerical, and sales workers. About 32% were medium business employees, minor professional, and technical staff, and about 35% were major business employees, executives, and professionals. Data collection took place from January 2017 until April 2017.

Procedure

Children and adolescents participating in the research completed a questionnaire measuring psychosocial phenomena such as in-group bias and sub-group identification (that is, identification with the Greek-Cypriot identity) that took 45 min to complete (one teaching

period). The construction of the questionnaire was based on a pilot testing in the period from October to December 2016 in order to ensure that all questions were understood, especially by the younger children. From the results of pilot testing, we concluded that some visual aids were need for questions measuring attitudes. The administration of questionnaires took place during class time, and their completion was supervised by assistant researchers who helped any student that faced difficulty with the comprehension of the questions. Concerning the general structure of the questionnaire, five-point Likert scales and thermometer scale were mostly used.

Dependent measure

Emotions towards Turkish Cypriots

This measured participant's attitudes towards people coming from the out-group (Turkish-Cypriot community). For this, a single item measure was used where participants had to express in a thermometer scale their feelings concerning Turkish Cypriots ("How do you feel towards Turkish-Cypriots?''). The thermometer question was found to work well in the past in measuring prejudice level in elementary school children (see Vezzali et al., 2018).

Predictor

In-group norms about being friendly towards Turkish Cypriots

This measure was the average score of four items (Mackie et al., 2012) measuring opinions regarding in-group norms being friendly with an out-group (Turkish Cypriots in our case) for family, teachers of primary/secondary school, friends, and classmates. The question was asked in a similar format concerning four different significant others "How acceptable is being friendly with Turkish Cypriots for your family members/teachers/friends/classmates?" Participants had to express their opinion on a 5-point scale where number 5 denoted the opinion as very important and number 1 the opinion as not important. Cronbach's of the scale was ($\alpha = 0.88$).

Moderator and mediator variables

Subgroup identification

This was the average score of four items being the following ones: (1) "Generally speaking I am proud of being Greek-Cypriot"; (2) "I often wish I was not a Greek-Cypriot" (reverse coded); (3) "I am proud of being a Greek-Cypriot"; (4) "The fact that I am a Greek Cypriot is the most important thing of who I am"; (5) "My national identity (the fact that I am a Greek Cypriot) can change (reverse coded)." The aforementioned items assessed the strength of identification participants maintained towards their group of national origin (Greek Cypriot community) and were adjusted from the well-established private collective self-esteem scale by Luhtanen and Crocker (1992) that was also used for children in the past (Verkuyten, 2007). In the scales, 5 represented the opinion "Absolutely agree" and 1 the opinion "Absolutely disagree." Cronbach's α was $\alpha = 0.73$.

Table 1 Independent samples *t* test of younger ages and older ages

Scale	Younger ages		Older ages		*t*	*df*	*p*
	M	*SD*	*M*	*SD*			
Emotions towards TCs	6.25	3.04	6.86	2.37	*−2.89*	*654*	*.004*
Positive in-group norms	3.15	.80	3.22	.94	*−1.12*	*688*	*.262*
Subgroup identification	3.87	.95	3.92	.72	*−.82*	*688*	*.411*
Realistic threat	3.34	.94	3.37	.99	*−.40*	*688*	*.686*
Symbolic threat	2.54	.89	2.74	.86	*−2.88*	*688*	*.004*

Realistic threat

This was the average score of two items (r(350) = 0.47 $p < 0.001$) inspired by Stephan and Stephan (2000) integrated threat theory assessing opinions concerning feelings of realistic threat. In particular, realistic threat was defined as the fear of people from one certain group (in our case Greek Cypriots) that out-group members (Turkish Cypriots) may influence in a negative way their economy, political power, or well-being. For example, "Turkish Cypriots can govern Cyprus together with Greek Cypriots (reverse coded)" and "The economy of Greek Cypriots will improve if we co-operate with Turkish Cypriots" (reverse coded). In these questions, participants had to express their agreement or disagreement with the above items, on a 5-point Likert scale.

Symbolic threat

This was the average score of the following two items: "Our traditions are threatened by Turkish Cypriots" and "Greek Cypriots are very different from the Turkish Cypriots concerning the way they think." Participants had to express their agreement or disagreement with items, measuring feelings of symbolic threat on the 5-point scale. The Pearson correlation between these two items was positive (r(389) = 0.24, $p < 0.001$). Both the realistic and symbolic threat items were adjusted from previous studies with students in late childhood and adolescence (Velasco González et al., 2008; Nshom & Croucher, 2017).

Results

We firstly compared the means of our variables in the two age groups (Table 1). The results suggested that the adolescents showed significantly higher levels of positive emotions towards Turkish Cypriots compared to the younger children. In particular, whilst the mean of the younger age group did not significantly differ from the midpoint of the scale ($t = 1.39$, $df = 292$, $p = 0.16$) in the case of older children, the mean was significantly more positive than the point of neutral feelings ($t = 7.17$, $df = 382$, $p < 0.001$). The positive in-group norm of the importance of being friendly towards Turkish Cypriots was significantly higher than the midpoint of 3 for both the younger ($t = 3.28$, $df = 302$, $p < 0.01$) and the older children ($t = 4.74$, $df = 376$, $p < 0.001$) suggesting that positive norms were recognized

by most students. However, as shown in Table 1, the means of the two age groups were not significantly different from each other.

Subgroup identification was quite high in both groups and significantly higher than the midpoint of 3 for both elementary ($t = 15.93$, $df = 302$, $p < 0.001$) and high school ($t = 25.1$, $df = 386$, $p < 0.001$) students. However, the means were not significantly different in the two age groups. Similarly, realistic threats were also high in both age groups and not significantly different from each other. As expected, they were both significantly higher than the midpoint of 3 for both children ($t = 6.32$, $df = 302$, $p < 0.001$) and adolescents ($t = 7.43$, $df = 386$, $p < 0.001$). Interestingly, symbolic threat was significantly lower than the midpoint of 3 for both children ($t = -8.80$, $df = 302$, $p < 0.001$) and adolescents ($t = -5.85$, $df = 386$, $p < 0.001$). As Table 1 suggest however, there was an increase in symbolic threat as children moved from childhood to adolescence.

The findings from the correlation table (Table 2) supported H1 since correlations between threats, positive norms, and prejudice were generally lower for younger compared to older children supporting the hypothesis that the intergroup focus would be higher in older children. Importantly, the strength of subgroup identification was unrelated to prejudice at both age groups which went against predictions from SIDT theory in H1. In-group norms of significant others were related to strength of subgroup identification in the younger age group but not the older age group which supported the idea that identification in middle childhood mostly relates to an interpersonal (in-group focus), rather than an inter-group focus that extends to the imagined community of B. Anderson. Correspondingly, realistic threat was negatively related to subgroup identification in the older but not the younger group suggesting some sense of "weaponization" of identification that could work through a sense of heightened threat, and specifically a set of thoughts that frame sharing power and economy with Turkish Cypriots as threatening. Realistic threat was negatively related to in-group norms in both age groups, albeit in a stronger way in the older group. The two types of threats were unrelated between them in the younger age group but moderately related in the older age group.

To test H2 whether positive in-group norms "trump" threats in older children, we first tested the moderation of the link between our independent (in-group norms) and dependent variable (emotion towards TCs) under different levels of threats with a simple moderation analysis using model 1 of the PROCESS macro from Hayes (2018). Gender and urbanization were included as covariates in this model.[1] The findings from this analysis are presented in Table 3 below.

For the younger age group, in-group norms were unrelated to emotions towards TCs and this was true irrespective of the levels of the three moderators (realistic threat and symbolic threat). On the contrary, for the older age group, the significance of in-group norms was greatly enhanced. First, they were related to the expression of higher positive feelings towards TCs, and maybe more importantly, they were buffering against the negative effects of realistic threat on prejudice. This was suggested by the significant interaction effect of the IV × realistic threat presented in Fig. 2 below thus supporting H2 that norms

[1] Gender (boy = 1, girl = 2) was significantly related to in-group norms ($r(385) = 0.23$, $p < 0.001$), symbolic threat ($r(385) = -0.17$, $p < 0.001$) and positive emotions towards TCs ($r(381) = 0.26$, $p < 0.001$) in older children. In younger children it was only related to subgroup identification ($r(297) = 0.15$, $p < 0.01$). Urbanization (1 = urban, 2 = rural) was significantly related to subgroup identification ($r(301) = 0.19$, $p < 0.001$), but only in the younger age group. All models were run with and without the controls and the significance and direction of the findings remained unchanged.

Table 2 Pearson correlations between the variables in the two age groups

		V1	V2	V3	V4	V5
V1	Emotions towards T/C	–-	.12*	.08	−.15*	−.21***
V2	In-group norms friendly with T/C	.38***	–-	.13*	−.17**	−.04
V3	Subgroup identification	−.03	−.03	–-	−.03	−.01
V4	Realistic threat	−.28***	−.23***	.13**	–-	.04
V5	Symbolic threat	−.29***	−.19**	.07	.36***	–-

Note: Above the diagonal are the correlations for the younger age group and below the diagonal for the older age group. The sample size of the correlations ranged from 271 to 303 in the younger age group and from 383 to 387 in the older age group

Table 3 In-group norm about being friendly towards TCs and emotions towards TCs: Moderations by realistic threat, symbolic threat, and strength of subgroup identification in the two age groups

Effect	Outcome	Independent variable (IV) in-group norms being friendly			
		Age group (7–12)		Age group (13–17)	
		B (*SE*)	95% CI	B (*SE*)	95% CI
IV (in-group norms friendly)	Emotions TCs	.34 (.23) ns	[−.11, .78]	.70 (.12)***	[.47, .94]
M (realistic threat)	Emotions TCs	−.40 (.19)*	[−.78, −.03]	−.50 (.11)***	[−.71, −.28]
IV X realistic threat	Emotions TCs	−.24 (.18) ns	[−.58, .11]	.35 (.11)***	[.13, .57]
Model summary		$R^2 = 0.06$, F (5,265) = 3.19, $p < 0.01$		$R^2 = 0.24$, F (5,377) = 23.52, $p < 0.001$	
IV (in-group norms friendly)	Emotions TCs	.38 (.22) ns	[−.05, .82]	.76 (.12)***	[.53, 1.00]
M (symbolic threat)	Emotions TCs	−.69 (.20)***	[−1.07, −.30]	−.57 (.13)***	[−.82, −.32]
IV X symbolic threat	Emotions TCs	.07 (.20) ns	[−.32, .45]	.01 (.12) ns	[−.23, .25]
Model summary		$R^2 = 0.08$, F (5,265) = 4.36, $p < 0.001$		$R^2 = 0.22$, F (5,377) = 21.48, $p < 0.001$	
IV (in-group norms friendly)	Emotions TCs	.40 (.23)ns	[−.04, .85]	.85 (.12)***	[.61, 1.08]
M (subgroup identification)	Emotions TCs	−.06 (.20)ns	[−.33,.44]	−.07 (.16)ns	[−.38, .24]
IV X subgroup identification	Emotions TCs	−.23 (.24) ns	[−.70, .23]	−.02 (.17) ns	[−.36, .32]
Model summary		$R^2 = 0.04$, F (5,265) = 2.10, $p < 0.10$		$R^2 = 0.18$, F (5,377) = 16.67, $p < 0.001$	

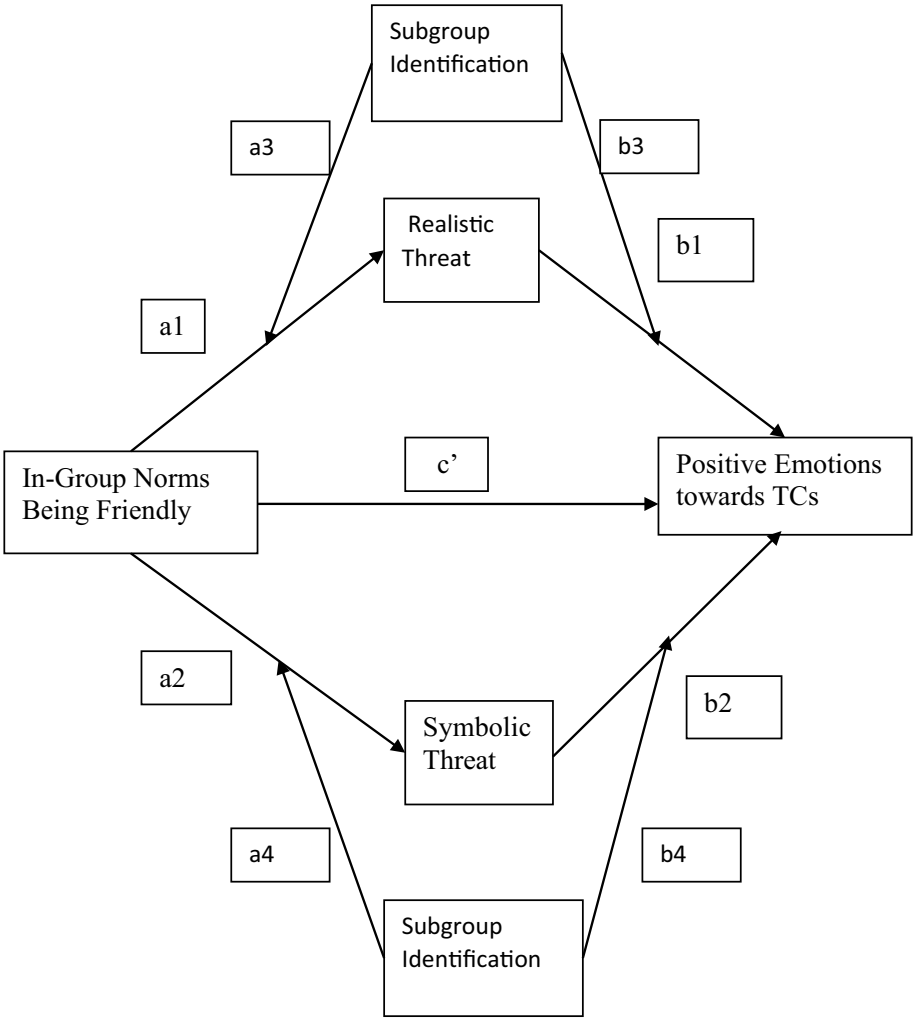

Fig. 1 The proposed moderated mediation model (PROCESS Model 58, Hayes , 2018)

trump threats in older (but not younger) children. To test H3, that strength of identification will increase the impact of in-group norms on the superficial expression of non-prejudicial views derived from normative influence models, we run a similar moderation model with subgroup identification but no significant moderation effect was detected in either of the age groups.

To test the deep internalization process of social influence, via the mediation of threats, we derived from GSP depicted in Fig. 1, and in our remaining hypothesis (H4), we run a moderated mediation analysis using the PROCESS macro from Hayes (2018), model 58. In this model, emotions towards TCs was entered as the dependent variable, in-group norms about the importance of being friendly towards TCs as independent variable, and the two types of threats (realistic and symbolic) as parallel mediators. Strength of subgroup identification was included as the moderator. Gender and urbanization were

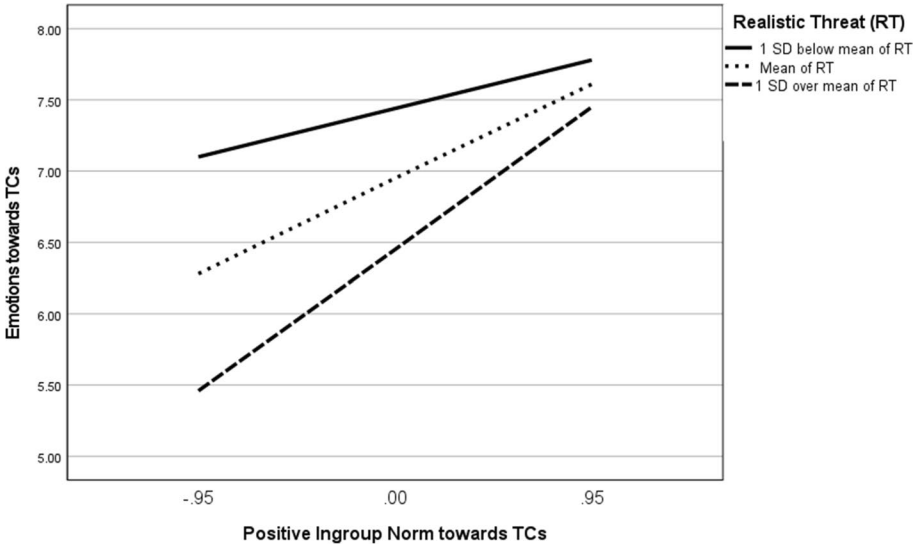

Fig. 2 Analysis of the moderation by realistic threat of the effect of in-group norms on emotions towards TCs for 12–17 year olds

again included as covariates in this model. The macro uses ordinary least squares (OLS) analysis for calculating the mediation and moderated mediation effects, and bootstrapping for calculating the confidence intervals (CI). We used bias-corrected bootstrap CIs based on 5000 bootstrap samples with a 95% level of confidence. When the confidence intervals do not include zero, the effect is interpreted as significant (Fig. 2).

For the age group 7–12, the moderated mediation model 58 explained only 10% of the variance in the outcome measure ($R^2 = 0.10$, F (8,262) = 3.53, $p < 0.001$) (Table 4). Specifically, it showed that positive in-group norms were negatively related to realistic threat (B = −0.22, 95% CI: −0.36 to −0.08) but not symbolic threat (B = −0.05, 95% CI: −0.19 to 08). However, both realistic (B = −0.38, 95% CI: −0.75 to −0.01) and symbolic threat (B = −0.69, 95% CI: −1.08 to −0.31) were significant predictors of positive emotions towards TCs. Thus, the indirect effect of in-group norms on positive emotions towards TCs was significant only through realistic threat (B = 0.09, 95% CI: −0.00 to 0.22).

However, the path (a2) from in-group norms to symbolic threat was significantly moderated by subgroup identification (B = −0.21, 95% CI: −0.35 to −0.07) (see Fig. 3 below). Further analysis revealed that path a2 became significant only for high identifiers (B = −0.26, 95% CI: −0.45 to −0.06). This resulted in a significant indirect effect of in-group norms on emotions towards TCs for high identifiers only (B = 0.23, 95% CI: 0.00 to 0.55).

For the age group 12–17, the moderated mediation model 58 explained 24% of the variance compared to the younger age group as expected (F (8,374) = 14.82, $p < 0.001$). This was largely due to the additional direct effect of in-group norms on positive emotions towards TCs (B = 0.69, 95% CI: 0.45 to 0.93).

As in the case of younger students, positive in-group norms were negatively related to realistic threat (B = −0.24, 95% CI: −0.35 to −0.14) and this time also to symbolic threat as expected (B = −0.16, 95% CI: −0.25 to −0.06). Again, both realistic (B = −0.34, 95%

Table 4 A moderated mediation model of positive in-group norms about being friendly towards TCs on emotions towards TCs through threats at various levels of subgroup identification in the two age groups

Effect	Outcome	Independent variable (IV) in-group norms being friendly			
		Age group (7–12)		Age group (13–17)	
		B (*SE*)	95% CI	B (*SE*)	95% CI
IV (a_1)	Realistic threat	−.22 (.07)***	[−.36, −.08]	−.24 (.05)***	[−.35, −.14]
IV (a_2)	Symbolic threat	−.05 (.07)ns	[−.19, .08]	−.16 (.05)***	[−.25, −.06]
Realistic threat (b_1)	Emotions TCs	−.38 (.19)*	[−.75, −.01]	−.34 (.12)***	[−.58, −.11]
Symbolic threat (b2)	Emotions TCs	−.69 (.20)***	[−1.08, −.31]	−.45 (.14)***	[−.71, −.18]
Direct effect of IV (c′)	Emotions TCs	.24 (.23)ns	[−.21, .68]	.69 (.12)***	[.45, .93]
Indirect effect (via realistic threat)	Emotions TCs	.09 (.06)*	[.00, .22]	.09 (.04)*	[.02, .17]
Indirect effect (via symbolic threat)	Emotions TCs	.04 (.06)ns	[−.08, .17]	.07 (.03)*	[.01, .15]
Moderated mediation analysis					
SI X IV (a_3)	Realistic threat	.13 (.08)ns	[−.02, 0.28]	−.03 (.08)ns	[−.18, 0.12]
SI X RT (b_3)	Emotions TCs	.03 (.18)ns	[−.33, .39]	−.14 (.17)ns	[−.47, .19]
SI X IV (a_4)	Symbolic threat	−.21 (.07)***	[−.35, -.07]	.15 (.07)*	[.02, .28]
SI X ST (b_4)	Emotions TCs	−.21 (.18)ns	[−.56, .14]	−.02 (.19)ns	[−.39, .36]
Conditional indirect effect through realistic threat					
Low subgroup ID	Emotions TCs	.14 (.13)	[−.04, .46]	.05 (.05)	[−.02, .16]
Mean subgroup ID	Emotions TCs	.08 (.05)*	[.00, .21]	.08 (.04)*	[.02, .17]
High subgroup ID	Emotions TCs	.03 (.06)	[−.05, .21]	.12 (.06)*	[.01, .24]
Conditional indirect effect through symbolic threat					
Low subgroup ID	Emotions TCs	−.07 (09)	[−.29, .07]	.12 (07)*	[.00, .27]
Mean subgroup ID	Emotions TCs	.04 (.06)	[−.09, .17]	.07 (.03)*	[.01, .15]
High subgroup ID	Emotions TCs	.23 (.15)*	[.00, .55]	.02 (.04)	[-.05, .11]

Notes: For each model, the other IVs, period of data collection, gender, and urbanization were controlled. B values are unstandardized regression coefficients *IV* independent variable, emotions TCs refer to positive attitudes toward Turkish Cypriots, *CI* confidence interval, *SE* standard error

a Paths on Fig. 1 are given in parentheses

b For parsimony reasons, only interaction effects and conditional indirect effect are reported. *$p<.05$;**$p<.01<.01$;**$p<.001$

CI: −0.58 to −0.11) and symbolic threat (B = −0.45, 95% CI: −0.71 to −0.18) were significant predictors of positive Emotions towards TCs.

Thus, both the indirect effects of in-group norms on positive emotions towards TCs were significant through realistic threat (B = 0.09, 95% CI: 0.02 to 0.17) and symbolic threat (B = 0.07, 95% CI: 0.01 to 0.15).

The path from in-group norms to symbolic threat (a2) was again significantly moderated by subgroup identification (B = 0.15, 95% CI: 0.02 to 0.28); however, this time the effect was the opposite of the one revealed for the younger age group (see Fig. 4 below) thus supporting H4. This finding applied to symbolic, but not realistic threat as expected. Further analysis revealed that path a2 became significant only for low (B = −0.26, 95% CI: −0.40 to −0.13) and moderate identifiers (B = −0.16, 95% CI: −0.25 to −0.06). This resulted in a significant indirect effect of in-group norms on emotions towards TCs only for

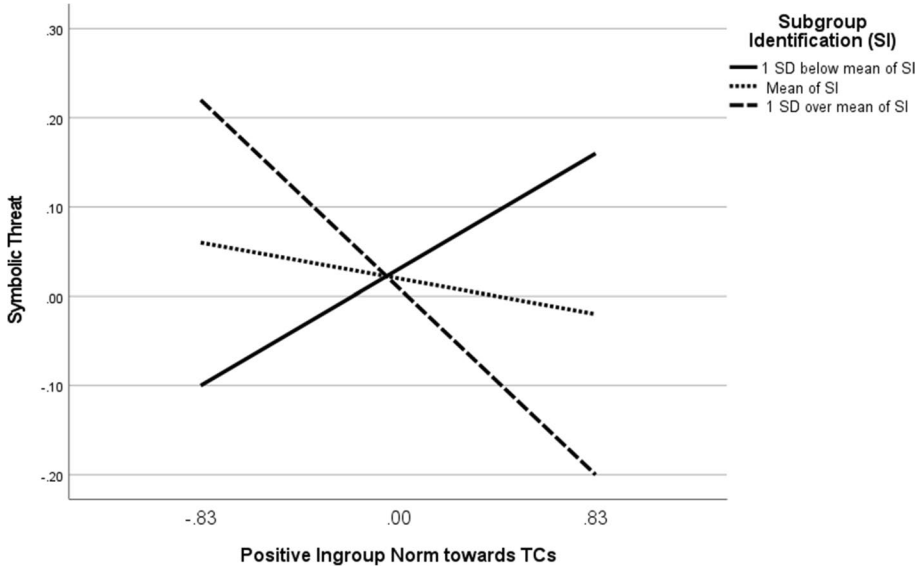

Fig. 3 Moderation of path a2 by subgroup identification for the age group 7–12

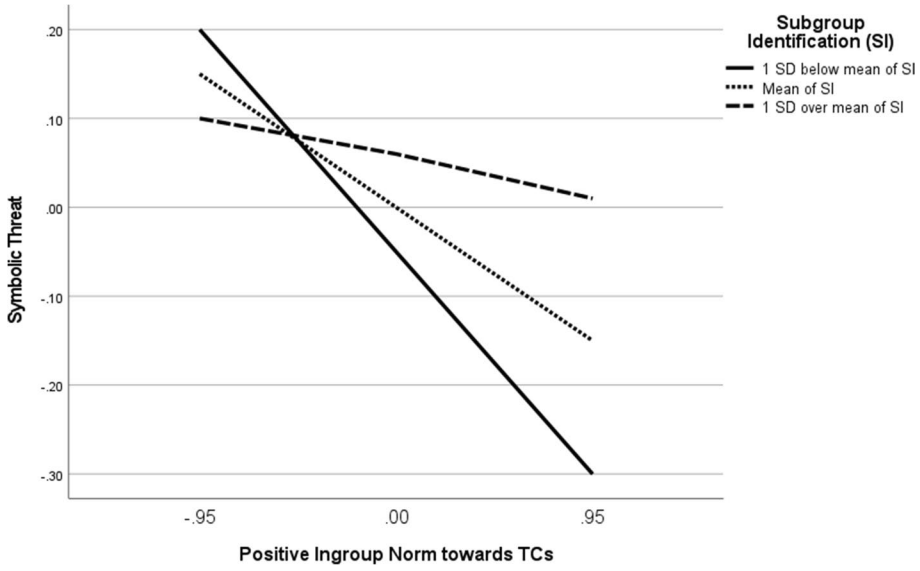

Fig. 4 Moderation of path a2 by subgroup identification for the age group 12–17

low identifiers (B = 0.12, 95% CI: 0.00 to 0.27) and identifiers of moderate levels (B = 0.07, 95% CI: 0.01 to 0.15).

Discussion

This paper explored the potential role played by positive in-group norms in the educational setting of a post-conflict and deeply divided society in the contested process of conflict transformation. The contribution of this paper goes beyond the addition of testing such models in the context of an ethnic conflict beyond the ones already tested in other societies regarding race relations but in expanding the purview of this exploration in the transition from childhood to adolescence making the important distinction between the superficial influence of positive in-group norms on the mere expression of non-prejudiced views with the deep change of prejudice reduction via threat reduction.

The findings presented here underlined the overall importance of positive in-group norms as they were found to relate to (a) the expression of positive feelings towards Turkish Cypriots, (b) buffering against the expression of negative feelings towards Turkish Cypriots by older children who felt high levels of realistic threat from Turkish Cypriots, and (c) the internalization of in-group norms through a process of ideological conversion related to reduced levels of both realistic and symbolic threats and prejudice levels.

The findings also reveal the working of resistance (Duveen, 2001) to the decrease of symbolic threats for high identifiers in adolescence which should be expected especially in post-conflict settings where the youth is politicized in the collective struggle of the in-group (Teichman & Bar-Tal, 2008).

The ontogenetic perspective in this paper was also of central importance as it allowed the comparison of the various mechanisms involved in the expression of prejudice between two age groups representing the elementary school years compared to the secondary school years. The findings support Aboud's (2008) claim that after seven years of age prejudice reduction should be expected and SIDT predictions that norms play a bigger role in older children. Future research that measures the cognitive developmental level of children should attempt to disentangle cognitive developmental from normative effects in this reduction. In the present findings, there is evidence that positive in-group norms contribute to this prejudice reduction especially in older children.

The present findings also give partial support to SIDT theory. The main findings were, consistent with SIDT, that children's prejudice was influenced by in-group norms as well as by out-group threat but were unrelated to strength of sub-group identification which is not in line with SIDT. This is probably due to the changing reference group in the transition from childhood to adolescence that can not offer a stable notion of identification irrespective of age group. Nevertheless, the findings are in line with Nesdale et al. (2005) who reported an interaction effect between in-group norms and threats. They found that 9 year olds compared to younger children did not differ from the neutral midpoint of the scale when the in-group had a norm of inclusion, regardless of whether the out-group did or did not threaten the in-group in a pattern where "norms trump threats." The present findings replicate this finding supporting the increasing importance for norms in regulating out-group emotions with age in accordance with normative beliefs about what is acceptable in a particular situation (Abrams & Rutland, 2008). Additionally, the present findings, in line with Piaget and Weil (1951), as well as Piaget (1932) and the Genetic Social Psychology (Psaltis, 2015) framework under development

go beyond Abrams and Rutland (2008) in that we recognize two routes for the working of positive norms on prejudice reduction. A direct (superficial compliance) and an indirect path through the reduction of feelings ofintergroup threat reduction and the reconstruction of knowledge or internalization of good quality intergroup relations supported by our testing of the moderated mediation model in this paper. We content that this reconstructive process of internalization of in-group norms via threat reduction itself be mediated by qualitative dialogue (either semantic with past and present out-group perspectives or actual physical intergroup contact) and is facilitated by a developmental shift from childhood which entails the reduction of relations of constraint (asymmetrical) and the emergence of more co-operative (symmetrical) interpersonal relationships. However, these mechanisms remain to be tested in future research.

The ontogenetic nature of our comparisons between younger children and older adolescents adds more complexity to the picture of prejudice development depicted by Aboud's socio-cognitive developmental theory and SIDT. The indirect path from in-group norms to prejudice reduction through symbolic threat is moderated by strength of sub-group identification. Younger children who highly identify with their subgroup are more likely to be influenced by positive in-group norms relating to peers, classmates, parents, and teachers, and experience lower levels of symbolic threat compared to children with lower identification. On the contrary, older adolescents with lower (but not higher) subgroup identification exhibit prejudice reduction through the same route.

All in all identification in this study is found to moderate one of the two routes of social influence processes. It was not found to moderate the expression of prejudice as predicted by theorists of normative influence (Jetten et al., 1998) in our testing of H3. As predicted by GSP in H4, it changes the dynamics of the reconstruction of knowledge about in-group and out-group and is a source of resistance (Duveen, 2001) which is not at all surprising given previous similar findings about the central role of social identity in learning and cognitive developmental internalization processes (Psaltis & Zapiti, 2014).

Future research in line with the GSP framework should further explore in comparisons between the age groups and longitudinal research that overcomes the limitations of cross-sectional analysis the following: (a) the impact of negative in-group norms on prejudice and their interaction with both symbolic and realistic threats, (b) the role of relations of constraint and relations of co-operation (Piaget, 1932), (c) the role of cognitive development; and (d) the changing role of intergroup contact in the two age groups. Such model testing will be in a position to explain more than 24% of variance that we were able to explain with the best fitting model here.

The present findings have also great practical importance for educational systems undergoing a process of transition and conflict transformation like Cyprus where an ethos of conflict makes the abundance of realistic threats (and with increasing age symbolic threats) highly likely, but where also the role of in-group norms proves crucial in both the suppression of the expression of prejudice and prejudice reduction efforts. The bi-communal technical committee in Cyprus could consider further educational interventions beyond the *Imagine* program towards social norms change program (Tankard & Paluck, 2016). For example, students and teachers who participated in the *Imagine* program could be given visibility through public awards. The great number of those who took part in the program (5,000 in the period 2016–2021) could be publicized and widely distributed, and finally, such information could be scaled up by mass media communication to wider society. The findings nevertheless could be generalized beyond Cyprus in that the pernicious impact of prejudice on learning processes is well documented and prejudice reduction should always be an aim of any educational system.

Another avenue that promotes relevant reconciliation attitudes is the promotion of a multiperspective approach to history teaching that overcomes the one-sided victimization narratives (Psaltis et al., 2017a). Such teaching can decrease adherence to one-sided narratives of victimization that were found to be linked with threats and distrust in various post-conflict settings (Psaltis et al., 2017b) thus activating the same route of prejudice reduction in the form of deeper ideological conversion towards conflict transformation. Such a step was not made possible in Cyprus yet, and this is unfortunately probably one of the major reasons of the repeated failed attempts to resolve the Cyprus problem.

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Declarations

Conflict of interest The authors declare no competing interests.

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Current themes of research:
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Most relevant publications in the field of Psychology of Education:
Kyriakides, M. (2020). Formation of prejudice and subgroup identification: the role of cognitive development and in-group and intergroup relations in children and adolescents. PhD thesis, Department of Psychology, University of Cyprus.

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Current themes of research:
Development of identities and prejudice in childhood, social representations of difference (gender, ethnicity) and social interaction, genetic social psychology

Most relevant publications in the field of Psychology of Education:
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